The Hidden System Behind a TikTok “Like”

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Technical Affordance

Algorithmic systems shape interaction through:
- Recommendation algorithms
- Engagement metrics
- Infinite scrolling
- Autoplay videos

Human Affordance

Human psychology drives engagement:
- Curiosity
- Emotional response
- Social approval
- Dopamine reward loop

Power Affordance

Platform owners control:
- Content visibility
- Recommendation rules
- Monetization systems

User behavior becomes a source of economic value.

User Action ➡ Data Collection ➡ Algorithm Processing ➡ Content Distribution ➡ Platform Value

User likes a video.

TikTok records engagement signals (likes, watch time, interactions).

Recommendation system updates user interest profile.

Video is recommended to other users.

More engagement increases and revenue.

Benefits

Personalized content
Entertainment
Creator visibility

Risks

Data tracking
Algorithmic bias
Addictive design
Information bubbles

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Reference

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When a user taps the like button, the platforms records this interaction as engagement data alongside other signals such as watch time, shares, comments, and viewing history. These signals are processed by TikTok's recommendation algorithms, which continuously update the uses' profile and evaluate the performance of the video. This process illustrates the interaction between technological design, human behavior, and platform power. Users are encouraged to engage through intuitive interface features and rapid emotional responses to short content. The platform exercises power by determining how engagement data is interpreted and how content visibility is distributed. These decisions influence which creators gain exposure and which content spread widely.

Each engagement action generates behavioral data that can be stored, analyzed, and used for targeted advertising, raising concerns about privacy. Recommendation algorithms may reinforce narrow content patterns, potentially creating information bubbles.